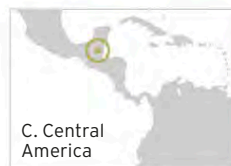




Tikal

*A city of towering temples, monuments, and palaces
and the center of a powerful Maya kingdom*



Today, the abandoned city of Tikal—once the capital of a powerful Maya kingdom—stands in the Tikal National Park, a UNESCO World Heritage Site in the Petén province of Guatemala. While many residential areas, irrigation stations, and administrative outposts are still engulfed by the tropical forest, the center of the city, which contains the principal monuments and public buildings, has been cleared.

Lost and found

The central zone has public squares, or plazas, built on terraces connected by roadways and accessed by ramps. The squares are surrounded by temples and palaces, along with other structures such as pyramids, ceremonial platforms, and

courts for the popular Maya ball games. The principal squares of the town are the Great Plaza, the Twin Pyramid complex, and the so-called “Lost World” complex (see panel, left). The Maya monuments there are among the finest yet discovered. Many of them are decorated with hieroglyphic inscriptions and paintings. These give an insight into the development of architectural and artistic styles at the site from its early settlement in the 4th century BCE to the time of Tikal’s regional dominance in the 9th century CE.

► EPICENTER OF TIKAL

Tikal’s Great Plaza consisted of a ball court and two temples, known as Temple 1 and Temple 2. Temple 1 (on the right in this image) was considered by the Maya to be a portal to the underworld.

